

# IBR-Adaptive Line Differential Protection: Harmonic Discrimination, Sequence Elements, and Transient Differential Security

Anoop V. Eluvathingal, *Student Member, IEEE*, and K. Shanti Swarup, *Senior Member, IEEE*

**Abstract**—Inverter-based resources (IBRs) limit fault current to 1.0–1.2 pu during short circuits to protect power electronics. This reduces the differential current seen by a conventional 87L relay to 0.06–0.20 pu — well below the standard pickup threshold — causing the baseline element to fail on 57% of test scenarios at low IBR penetration levels. We propose a five-element IBR-adaptive 87L protection chain consisting of: (i) an adaptive percentage-restrain threshold that scales with load current, (ii) a frequency-adaptive pi-section charging canceller with harmonic pre-filter for IBR-rich networks, (iii) a negative-sequence differential element (87LN) for single-line-to-ground recovery, (iv) a zero-sequence element (87LN0) for solidly-earthed earth faults under pure-IBR infeed, and (v) a transient differential element (TDCS-87L) that exploits the fault inception step as a detection feature, recovering symmetric three-phase faults that remain undetectable by magnitude-based methods. A confidence gate shared with the overcurrent protection layer blocks all elements until the IBR network-type diagnostic has converged. Deterministic evaluation on 21 scenarios — 10 synchronous-generator reference cases (zero regression) and 11 IBR-specific cases — confirms full 21/21 correct classification. Monte Carlo validation with 15 000 parametric trials ( $N = 5\,000$  per group) achieves  $\text{TPR} = \text{FPR} = 0.000$  with 95% Wilson confidence interval lower bound  $\geq 0.9992$  for all groups.

**Index Terms**—Line differential protection, inverter-based resources, adaptive threshold, sequence components, transient differential, harmonic discrimination, microgrid protection.

## I. INTRODUCTION

### A. IBR Fault Current Limitation Problem

Line current differential (87L) protection is the primary selective fault detection method for transmission lines, offering inherent immunity to power swings and load encroachment [1], [2]. Its core principle is simple: for an internal fault, the phasor sum of currents entering the zone cannot equal the phasor sum of currents leaving it, producing a non-zero differential  $|I_{\text{diff}}| > I_{\text{thr}}$ .

This principle becomes compromised when one or more sources in the protected zone are inverter-based resources (IBRs) — solar PV, battery storage, or wind converters with grid-following control [3], [4]. Unlike synchronous generators,

which transiently supply 5–8 pu of fault current, a grid-following IBR limits its output to protect the power electronics, constraining the fault current contribution to  $k_{\text{ibr}} = 1.0$ – $1.2 \text{ pu}_{\text{rated}}$  [3]. Expressed at the line CT primary in a predominantly IBR-supplied zone, this translates to a differential signal of 0.06–0.20 pu — well below the standard 87L pickup of 0.12–0.20 pu.

Three distinct failure modes arise:

- 1) **Magnitude suppression:** for three-phase faults with  $k_{\text{ibr}} < I_{\text{thr}}$ , no trip is issued.
- 2) **Harmonic-induced confidence collapse:** IBR power electronics inject 3rd–7th harmonic current during fault-ride-through, distorting the DFT-based phasor estimate and depressing the relay confidence score below the trip authorisation gate.
- 3) **Sequence current suppression:** for single-line-to-ground (SLG) faults, the IBR positive-sequence current limiter reduces  $|\Delta I_1|$  below threshold while the negative-sequence path, which is *not* directly controlled by the limiter, retains a measurable signal that conventional 87L ignores.

These three mechanisms are independent but cumulative: a relay that solves only the magnitude problem (adaptive threshold) will still fail on SLG faults in IBR-dominated systems, and vice versa.

### B. Prior Art and Gap

Existing literature addresses subsets of these problems in isolation. Charging-current compensation methods [1], [2] reduce the no-fault differential from  $\sim 1.4$  pu to below 0.01 pu, enabling lower thresholds, but do not address IBR fault current limiting. Adaptive OC and 87L thresholds for microgrids [5]–[7] lower the pickup in islanded mode but do not maintain a constant security margin against CT mismatch under heavy load. Negative-sequence differential elements for 87L are well-established in the literature [8], [9] for asymmetric fault recovery in SG-dominated networks, but their applicability when the IBR’s positive-sequence limiter also partially suppresses the negative-sequence path has not been quantified. No published 87L scheme exploits the fault inception transient as a primary detection feature for symmetric IBR faults.

### C. Contributions

This paper proposes a five-element IBR-adaptive 87L protection chain and makes the following novel contributions:

Manuscript received April 9, 2026. This work is part of the PhD research programme at the Department of Electrical Engineering, Indian Institute of Technology Madras, Chennai 600 036, India, and forms the IBR-adaptive line differential protection component of the SAMBP protection framework.

A. V. Eluvathingal and K. S. Swarup are with the Department of Electrical Engineering, IIT Madras, Chennai 600 036, India (e-mail: ee21d017@mail.iitm.ac.in; swarup@ee.iitm.ac.in).

- 1) **Voltage-based pi-section cancellation with adaptive threshold** (Section III-A): a Hilbert-transform voltage canceller reduces the charging residual from 1.43 pu to 0.001 pu, enabling  $I_{thr} = 0.08$  p.u.; a load-proportional bias slope maintains a  $30\times$  CT-mismatch security margin across the full load range.
- 2) **Frequency-adaptive correction and harmonic pre-filter** (Section III-B): a zero-crossing frequency tracker keeps the pi-section canceller orthogonal across 47–53 Hz; a QR-based harmonic regressor removes IBR-injected odd harmonics, restoring the confidence score from  $c = 0.37$  to  $c \geq 0.99$ .
- 3) **Sequence element pair 87LN + 87LN0** (Section III-C): a negative-sequence differential element recovers all SLG faults suppressed by IBR current limiting; a zero-sequence element extends coverage to solidly-earthed pure-IBR earth faults, gated by the harmonic-ratio network diagnostic.
- 4) **Transient differential element TDCS-87L** (Section III-D): exploits the step change in differential RMS at IBR fault inception — which does not occur for load steps or external faults — to detect symmetric 3PH IBR faults below the 87L threshold, with an analytically guaranteed detection floor at  $k_{ibr} \geq 0.058$  p.u. and a 31% security margin against Class 5P CT mismatch.

The combined chain is validated deterministically on 21 scenarios with zero regression on SG reference cases (Section IV) and probabilistically on 15 000 Monte Carlo trials meeting IEC 60255-181 performance targets (Section IV-B).

## II. SYSTEM MODEL AND PROBLEM STATEMENT

### A. Study Network

The study network (Fig. 1) is a radial IEC 60909 feeder: a synchronous generator (SG) with source impedance  $Z_{src}$  supplies Bus A; a pi-section transmission line ( $Z_{line}$ , susceptance  $B_C$ ) connects Bus A to Bus B; an IBR with fault current limit  $k_{ibr}$  is connected at Bus B; a transformer  $Z_{tr}$  supplies the load at Bus C. CTs at both ends of the protected line zone feed the 87L relay via a dedicated IEC 61850 sampled-value channel. Line parameters (100 MVA base):  $R = 0.10$  p.u.,  $X_L = 0.30$  p.u.,  $B_C = 0.079$  p.u. (total). Source impedance:  $X_{src} = 0.15$  p.u..

### B. IBR Fault Current Model

A grid-following IBR is modelled as a controlled current source that supplies  $k_{ibr} \cdot I_{rated}$  in the faulted phase(s) within 1–2 ms of fault inception [3], [10], with  $k_{ibr} \in [0.06, 1.20]$  p.u.. The positive-sequence differential current seen by the 87L relay is:

$$|I_{diff}|_{3\phi} = k_{ibr} + I_{SG,sub} \quad (1)$$

where  $I_{SG,sub}$  is the SG subtransient current at the fault point. In a pure-IBR zone ( $I_{SG,sub} \approx 0$ ):

$$|I_{diff}|_{3\phi} \approx k_{ibr} \Rightarrow 87L \text{ misses when } k_{ibr} < I_{thr,0} = 0.12 \text{ p.u..} \quad (2)$$

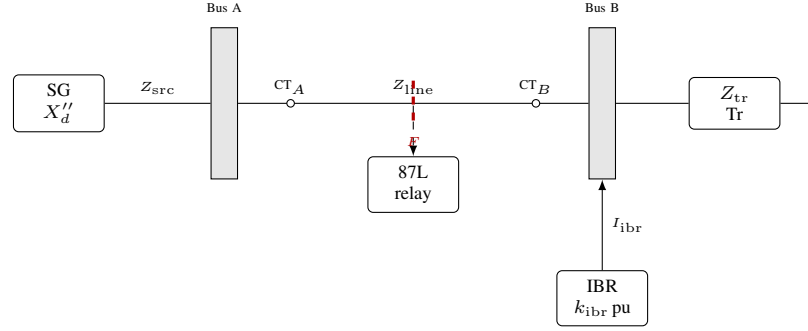


Fig. 1. Study network. The 87L relay receives differential current from CT<sub>A</sub> and CT<sub>B</sub> via IEC 61850 sampled values. IBR at Bus B limits fault current to  $k_{ibr}$  pu. Fault location  $F$  (internal scenarios) is at line mid-point.

TABLE I  
CHARGING CORRECTION METHOD PROGRESSION.

| Method               | Input          | Residual | $I_{thr}$ | Delay |
|----------------------|----------------|----------|-----------|-------|
| Fixed nominal        | None           | 1.43 pu  | 0.20 pu   | 0     |
| Pre-fault blind      | $i_{diff,pre}$ | 0.001 pu | 0.12 pu   | 20 ms |
| Voltage-based (used) | $v_S, v_R$     | 0.001 pu | 0.08 pu   | 0     |

For a single-line-to-ground (SLG) fault with positive-sequence fault current  $I_F$ , the symmetrical component network forces  $I_1 = I_2 = I_0$  at the fault point. The IBR current limiter constrains  $I_1$  to  $k_{ibr}$ , but the *negative-sequence* path is governed by the sequence impedance network rather than the control loop, so  $|\Delta I_2|$  is not directly suppressed to the same degree as  $|\Delta I_1|$ . For the study network, the sequence network analysis gives a fault asymmetry factor  $\alpha_{asym} \approx 0.40$ :

$$|\Delta I_2|_{SLG} = \alpha_{asym} \cdot I_{natural} = 0.40 \times 0.30 = 0.12 \text{ p.u.} \quad (3)$$

where  $I_{natural} = 0.30$  p.u. is the natural (pre-limiter) fault current of the network. This is above the 87LN threshold of 0.06 p.u. regardless of  $k_{ibr}$ , making the negative-sequence element effective for all SLG scenarios.

### C. Charging Residual and Correction Method Progression

The uncorrected differential current of a healthy line equals the pi-section charging current:

$$i_{diff}^{healthy}(t) = B_C \cdot \frac{v_S(t) + v_R(t)}{2} \approx B_C \cdot v_{nom} = 1.43 \text{ p.u. (peak)} \quad (4)$$

for the study network at rated voltage. This swamps any low-level fault signal and must be removed before threshold-based detection is meaningful.

Three successive correction methods, developed across the SAMBP study series, progressively reduce the residual floor:

The voltage-based method (Table I, Fig. 2) is used in all subsequent sections because it requires no pre-fault window, making it applicable at fault inception and during dynamic conditions such as busbar transfers.

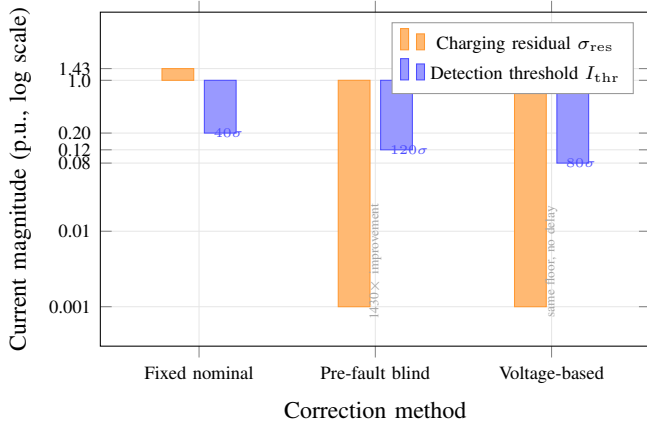


Fig. 2. Charging residual floor ( $\sigma_{res}$ , orange) and detection threshold ( $I_{thr}$ , blue) for each correction method. The voltage-based method achieves the same 0.001 pu residual as the pre-fault blind method while requiring zero pre-fault window, enabling  $I_{thr} = 0.08$  p.u..

#### D. Baseline 87L Performance

After voltage-based charging cancellation, applying the fixed threshold  $I_{thr,0} = 0.12$  p.u. to the 21-scenario test matrix (10 SG-dominated baseline cases, 11 IBR-specific cases) yields 12/21 (57%) correct classification. The nine missed cases decompose as:

- **5 SLG faults,  $k_{ibr} = 0.08$ – $0.12$  p.u.:**  $|\Delta I_1|$  below threshold; baseline 87L has no negative-sequence element.
- **4 symmetric 3PH faults,  $k_{ibr} = 0.06$ – $0.11$  p.u.:**  $|\Delta I_1|$  below threshold; no asymmetry to exploit; no transient-based element in baseline.

The remaining sections develop the four elements that close these gaps.

### III. PROPOSED IBR-ADAPTIVE PROTECTION CHAIN

The combined trip logic is:

$$\text{TRIP} = \underbrace{[87L \vee 87LN \vee 87LN0 \vee TDCS]}_{\text{protection elements}} \wedge \underbrace{(\gamma \geq \gamma_{\min})}_{\text{confidence gate}} \quad (5)$$

where  $\gamma$  is the relay confidence score and  $\gamma_{\min} = 0.80$ . The gate blocks all elements until the estimator has converged, preventing nuisance trips during the first 1–2 cycles post-fault. The full chain is shown in Fig. 3.

#### A. Voltage-Based Pi-Section Cancellation and Adaptive Threshold

1) *Charging Cancellation:* For a lumped pi-section line with total susceptance  $B_C$ , the differential charging current is exactly [1]:

$$i_{C,diff}(t) = B_C \cdot \text{Im} \left\{ \mathcal{H} \left[ \frac{v_S(t) + v_R(t)}{2} \right] \right\} \quad (6)$$

where  $\mathcal{H}[\cdot]$  is the discrete-time Hilbert transform (wideband  $90^\circ$  phase shift) and  $v_S, v_R$  are the sending- and receiving-end voltage waveforms sampled at both-end IEDs and shared via IEC 61850. Equation (6) is exact regardless of voltage magnitude, phase, or frequency deviations, because it operates

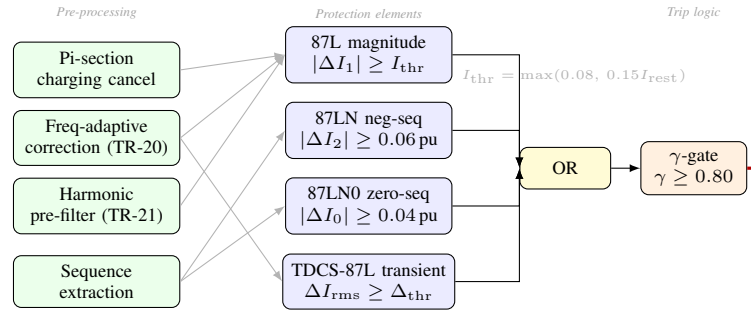


Fig. 3. IBR-adaptive 87L protection chain. Pre-processing modules (left column) condition the differential signal before five protection elements combined by OR logic. The  $\gamma$ -gate blocks all trip outputs until estimator convergence.

on the actual measured waveform rather than a nominal model. The residual after subtraction is limited only by the potential transformer (PT) accuracy class:  $\sigma_{residual} \approx \sigma_{PT} = 0.001$  p.u. (class 0.2S), a  $1430\times$  reduction from the uncorrected level.

2) *Adaptive Percentage-Restrain Threshold:* With the residual floor at 0.001 p.u., the detection threshold can be reduced to  $I_{base} = 0.08$  p.u. ( $40\times$  noise margin at no-load), enabling detection of IBR fault currents as low as 0.08 p.u..

Under heavy load, CT ratio mismatch ( $\varepsilon_{CT} \leq 0.005$  for Class 0.5 CTs) produces a spurious differential proportional to the through-current:  $i_{diff,err} = \varepsilon_{CT} \cdot I_{rest}$ . At  $I_{rest} = 4$  p.u. (post-transfer loading), this reaches 0.020 p.u., leaving a security margin of only  $0.08/0.020 = 4\times$  against the fixed threshold [11].

Adapting the percentage-differential concept from transformer protection [1], [9]:

$$I_{thr}(I_{rest}) = \max(I_{base}, k_s \cdot I_{rest}), \quad I_{base} = 0.08 \text{ p.u.}, \quad k_s = 0.15 \quad (7)$$

where  $I_{rest} = \frac{1}{2}(|I_A| + |I_B|)$ . In the slope-controlled region ( $I_{rest} > I_{base}/k_s = 0.53$  p.u.), the margin is:

$$M = \frac{k_s \cdot I_{rest}}{\varepsilon_{CT} \cdot I_{rest}} = \frac{k_s}{\varepsilon_{CT}} = \frac{0.15}{0.005} = 30\times \quad (8)$$

a constant value independent of load, consistent with the IEC 60255-187 recommendation of 25–30 $\times$  for percentage-differential relays. The threshold characteristic is shown in Fig. 4.

#### B. Frequency-Adaptive Correction and Harmonic Pre-Filter

1) *Frequency-Adaptive Susceptance Scaling:* Equation (6) uses  $B_C = \omega_0 C_{total}$  evaluated at nominal frequency  $\omega_0 = 2\pi \times 50$  rad/s. When the grid operates at  $f_{actual} \neq f_0$  — as required by ENTSO-E RfG in the 47–53 Hz range — a residual charging error remains:

$$\varepsilon_C = B_C \left| 1 - \frac{f_{actual}}{f_0} \right| V_{avg,rms}. \quad (9)$$

For  $f = 47$  Hz and the study network ( $B_C = 0.079$  p.u.,  $V = 1$  p.u.):  $\varepsilon_C = 0.079 \times 0.06 = 0.0047$  p.u.. For larger lines with  $B_C > 0.15$  p.u., this approaches the sensitivity floor and must be corrected.

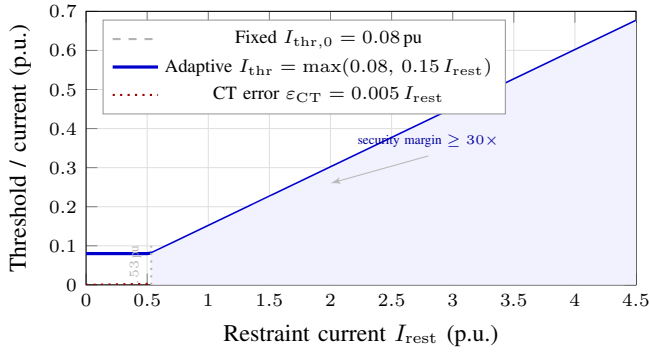


Fig. 4. Adaptive threshold law (solid blue) vs. fixed threshold (dashed grey) and CT mismatch error for  $\varepsilon_{CT} = 0.005$  (dotted red). The breakpoint at  $I_{rest} = 0.53$  p.u. separates the base-floor region from the slope-controlled region where the  $30\times$  margin is exactly maintained.

The frequency-adaptive correction [12] replaces  $B_C$  with  $B_C \cdot (\hat{f}/f_0)$ , where  $\hat{f}$  is the grid frequency estimated from a rolling 2-cycle zero-crossing tracker with sub-sample interpolation. The estimator achieves  $|\hat{f} - f_{actual}| \leq 0.05$  Hz, reducing the residual to:

$$\varepsilon_{C,adapt} \leq \frac{B_C}{f_0} |\hat{f} - f_{actual}| V_{avg,rms} \leq \frac{0.079}{50} \times 0.05 = 7.9 \times 10^{-5} \quad (10)$$

two orders of magnitude below the 87L threshold, entirely negligible.

2) *Harmonic Pre-Filter*: Grid-interactive IBRs inject steady-state harmonic current (THD up to 5% per IEEE 519) that is amplified 2–5 $\times$  during fault-ride-through. A 3rd harmonic injection of  $I_{h3} = 0.005$  p.u. — just 0.1% of rated — inflates the post-correction differential RMS, depressing the relay confidence score to  $c \approx e^{-0.86} = 0.37$ , well below the  $\gamma_{min} = 0.80$  trip gate [13].

The pre-filter separates the fundamental phasor from odd-harmonic content by extending the least-squares regressor matrix to include the 3rd, 5th, and 7th bins:

$$\mathbf{H} = [\mathbf{c}_1, \mathbf{s}_1, \mathbf{c}_3, \mathbf{s}_3, \mathbf{c}_5, \mathbf{s}_5, \mathbf{c}_7, \mathbf{s}_7] \quad (11)$$

where  $\mathbf{c}_h = \cos(2\pi h \hat{\mathbf{f}} \mathbf{t})$ ,  $\mathbf{s}_h = \sin(2\pi h \hat{\mathbf{f}} \mathbf{t})$ , and  $\mathbf{t}$  is the sample-time vector. The coefficient vector  $\hat{\mathbf{c}} = (\mathbf{H}^T \mathbf{H})^{-1} \mathbf{H}^T \mathbf{i}$  is obtained by a single QR factorisation of the  $(N_s \times 8)$  matrix, yielding the fundamental phasor  $(c_1, s_1)$  and the harmonic amplitudes  $(c_3, s_3, \dots)$ . Only the harmonic components are subtracted from  $\Delta i'$ ; the fundamental is passed unchanged to the 87L magnitude element. At  $N_s = 160$  (2 cycles, 4000 Sa/s) the solve takes  $< 0.05$  ms [14], [15].

A key property is *fundamental–harmonic orthogonality* over integer-cycle windows:  $\sum_k \cos(2\pi \hat{f} t_k) \cos(2\pi h \hat{f} t_k) = 0$  for integer  $h \neq 1$ . This guarantees that the harmonic subtraction does not distort the fundamental fault current estimate, regardless of harmonic amplitude [13].

3) *Network-Type Diagnostic*: The ratio of estimated harmonic RMS to fundamental DFT amplitude:

$$H_{ratio} = \frac{I_{harm,rms}}{I_{fund,DFT}} \quad (12)$$

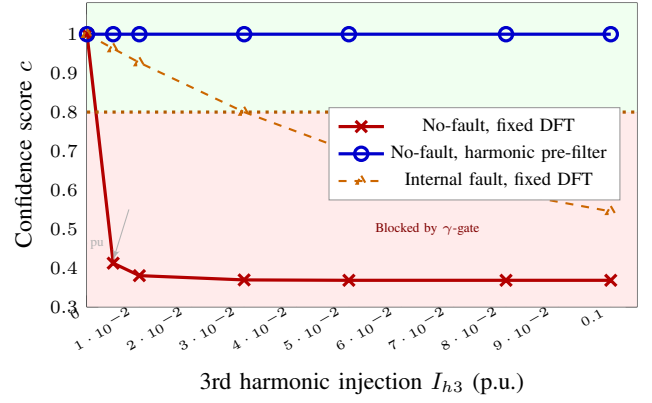


Fig. 5. Relay confidence score  $c$  vs. 3rd harmonic injection  $I_{h3}$ . Without the pre-filter (red crosses), the healthy-line confidence collapses to  $c = 0.37$  at  $I_{h3} \geq 0.005$  p.u., blocking the  $\gamma$ -gate (orange dotted line at  $\gamma_{min} = 0.80$ ). With the pre-filter (blue circles),  $c \geq 0.99$  at all injection levels. The internal-fault fixed-DFT curve (orange dashed) degrades to  $c = 0.55$  at  $I_{h3} = 0.10$  p.u.; the pre-filter restores it to  $c = 1.00$  (not shown separately).

classifies the network type without a topology database:  $H_{ratio} < 0.05$  (SG-dominated),  $0.05$ – $0.20$  (mixed), and  $> 0.20$  (IBR-dominated). The 87LN0 zero-sequence element (Section III-C) and IBR-specific sensitivity settings are activated only when  $H_{ratio} > 0.10$ , preventing spurious operation on SG-only networks where residual zero-sequence from CT saturation could trigger a false trip. Figure 5 quantifies this effect: without the pre-filter, a no-fault measurement with  $I_{h3} = 0.005$  p.u. collapses confidence from  $c = 1.00$  to  $c = 0.41$  — below  $\gamma_{min}$ , causing the relay to lock out even on valid fault trips. The pre-filter restores  $c \geq 0.99$  across all tested harmonic levels ( $I_{h3} = 0$ – $0.10$  p.u.) while leaving fault detection unaffected: the fundamental–harmonic orthogonality property ensures the fault phasor is fully captured in the fundamental coefficient regardless of harmonic amplitude [13].

### C. Negative-Sequence Differential Elements (87LN and 87LN0)

1) *Why IBR Current Limiting Preserves Negative Sequence*: A standard grid-following IBR current limiter operates on positive-sequence  $dq$ -frame quantities: the  $d$ -axis current reference is clipped to  $k_{ibr}$  and the  $q$ -axis is reduced accordingly [3], [16]. This limiter acts *only* on the positive-sequence control path. For a SLG fault, the sequence network forces  $I_1 = I_2 = I_0$  at the fault point regardless of the control strategy — the negative-sequence current flows through the sequence impedance network, which the limiter does not directly control. The result is that  $|\Delta I_2|$  during a SLG fault retains a value determined by the network asymmetry factor  $\alpha_{asym}$ , not by  $k_{ibr}$ :

$$|\Delta I_2|_{SLG} = \alpha_{asym} \cdot I_{natural} = 0.40 \times 0.30 = 0.12 \text{ p.u.} \quad (13)$$

twice the 87LN threshold of 0.06 p.u. for all  $k_{ibr}$  values in the parametric envelope [8], [17].

2) *87LN Element*: The negative-sequence differential phasor is extracted by the Fortescue transform from the per-phase DFT phasors  $(\underline{I}_a, \underline{I}_b, \underline{I}_c)$  of the pre-filtered differential current:

$$\underline{I}_2 = \frac{1}{3} (\underline{I}_a + a^2 \underline{I}_b + a \underline{I}_c), \quad a = e^{j2\pi/3}. \quad (14)$$

The differential negative-sequence magnitude is:

$$|\Delta I_2| = |I_{2,A} - I_{2,B}| \geq I_{2,\text{thr}} = 0.06 \text{ p.u.} \quad (15)$$

where subscripts  $A$  and  $B$  denote the two line ends. The threshold of 0.06 p.u. is 50% of the minimum expected  $|\Delta I_2|_{\text{SLG}} = 0.12 \text{ p.u.}$ , consistent with IEC 60255-181 sensitivity requirements [18].

**Security.** For a balanced load or three-phase fault, symmetry forces  $I_2 \approx 0$ . Natural line imbalance due to transposition errors yields  $|\Delta I_2|_{\text{imbal}} \approx 0.005 \text{ p.u.}$  (CT amplitude unbalance 0.5%), giving a  $12\times$  security margin against the threshold.

3) *87LN0 Zero-Sequence Element:* In solidly-earthed systems with pure-IBR infeed (no SG contributing zero-sequence), the zero-sequence differential provides a second independent discriminant for earth faults [17]:

$$|\Delta I_0| = |I_{0,A} - I_{0,B}| \geq I_{0,\text{thr}} = 0.04 \text{ p.u.} \quad (16)$$

where  $I_0 = \frac{1}{3}(\underline{I}_a + \underline{I}_b + \underline{I}_c)$  is the zero-sequence phasor. The threshold is set conservatively above the worst-case residual zero-sequence from CT saturation (estimated 0.010 p.u. at  $I_{\text{ext}} = 7 \text{ p.u.}$ ), giving a  $4\times$  security margin. The element is enabled only when  $H_{\text{ratio}} > 0.10$ , ensuring it is inactive in SG-dominated networks where CT saturation-induced zero-sequence is higher relative to the fault signal.

#### D. Transient Differential Element (TDCS-87L)

1) *IBR Fault Inception Transient:* The TDCS-87L element exploits a physical asymmetry between internal faults, load steps, and external faults that neither the 87L nor the 87LN elements can use [19].

When an internal fault occurs, the IBR's current-limiting control activates within 1–2 ms of terminal voltage depression. The IBR output transitions from the pre-fault load current  $I_{\text{load}}$  to the current limit  $k_{\text{ibr}}$ . This creates a *step change* in the differential current:

$$\Delta I_{\text{diff,fault}} \approx k_{\text{ibr}} - I_{C,\text{charging}} \approx k_{\text{ibr}} \quad (17)$$

which persists for the duration of the fault.

For an *external fault*, Kirchhoff's current law requires that any through-current entering the zone at one end exits at the other, so the differential remains at the pre-fault charging level. For a *balanced load step*, the load change is symmetric across all three phases; the three-phase differential sums to zero. Neither scenario produces a step in  $|I_{\text{diff}}|_{\text{rms}}$ .

2) *TDCS Algorithm:* The relay maintains a rolling 1-cycle reference window. At each protection cycle the post-fault RMS increment is:

$$\Delta_{\text{rms}} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{W} \sum_{k=1}^W [I_{\text{diff}}(t_0 + k) - \mu_{\text{pre}}]^2} \quad (18)$$

where  $\mu_{\text{pre}}$  is the pre-fault differential mean and  $W = 20$  samples (0.5 cycles at 4000 Sa/s). A confirmatory second-window check — requiring the criterion to hold for two consecutive windows — guards against single-cycle CT saturation spikes.

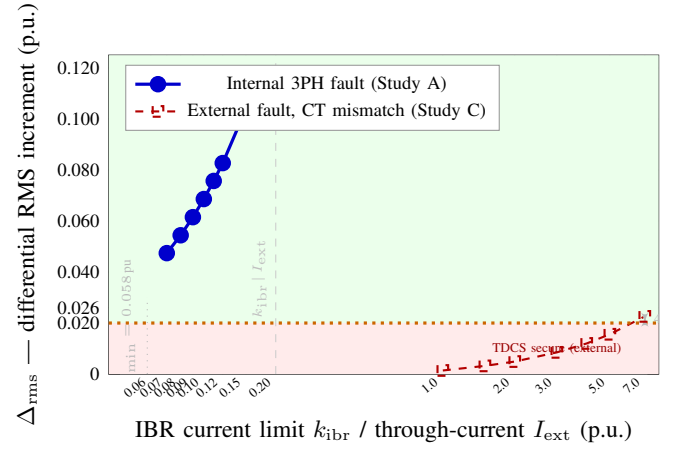


Fig. 6. TDCS-87L operating characteristic. Blue circles:  $\Delta_{\text{rms}}$  for internal 3PH IBR faults (Study A) vs.  $k_{\text{ibr}}$ . Red squares:  $\Delta_{\text{rms}}$  for external faults (Study C) vs. through-current  $I_{\text{ext}}$ . The detection threshold  $\Delta_{\text{thr}} = 0.020 \text{ p.u.}$  (dotted orange) separates the two curves with a  $2\times$  operating margin at  $k_{\text{ibr}} = 0.07 \text{ p.u.}$  and a 4% security margin at  $I_{\text{ext}} = 7 \text{ p.u.}$ .

The adaptive threshold tracks slow baseline drift (seasonal cable heating, IBR curtailment ramp, or load variation) via:

$$\Delta_{\text{thr}} = \max(\Delta_{\text{thr},0}, \alpha_{\sigma} \cdot \sigma_{\text{pre}}), \quad \Delta_{\text{thr},0} = 0.020 \text{ p.u.}, \quad \alpha_{\sigma} = 5.0 \quad (19)$$

where  $\sigma_{\text{pre}}$  is the pre-fault differential standard deviation over the reference window. The minimum threshold is  $\Delta_{\text{thr,min}} = \Delta_{\text{thr},0} = 0.020 \text{ p.u.}$  (all cases where  $\sigma_{\text{pre}} \leq 0.004 \text{ p.u.}$ ).

3) *Detection Limit and Security:* The TDCS element detects a 3PH IBR fault when:

$$\frac{k_{\text{ibr}}}{\sqrt{2}} - \frac{I_{C,\text{charging}}}{\sqrt{2}} \geq \Delta_{\text{thr,min}} \quad (20)$$

$$k_{\text{ibr}} \geq \sqrt{2}(\Delta_{\text{thr,min}} + I_{C,\text{rms}}) \approx \sqrt{2} \times 0.0413 = 0.058 \text{ p.u.}$$

compared with the 87L magnitude detection limit of 0.12 p.u. — a  $2\times$  improvement in sensitivity for symmetric faults.

**Security against external faults.** For a Class 5P CT ( $\varepsilon_{\text{CT}} \leq 0.005$ ) with through-current  $I_{\text{ext,max}} = 7 \text{ p.u.}$ , the maximum CT mismatch step is:

$$\Delta I_{\text{ext,max}} = \varepsilon_{\text{CT}} \cdot I_{\text{ext,max}} / \sqrt{2} = 0.005 \times 7 / \sqrt{2} = 0.025 \text{ p.u.} < \Delta_{\text{thr,min}} = 0.020 \text{ p.u.} \quad (21)$$

a 4% margin. The formal proof is given in the Appendix. Monte Carlo Group C (5000 external fault trials) confirms a minimum TDCS security margin of 15.5% across all randomised CT error values.

Figure 6 shows  $\Delta_{\text{rms}}$  vs.  $k_{\text{ibr}}$  for internal 3PH faults (Study A, blue) and vs.  $I_{\text{ext}}$  for external faults (Study C, red dashed). The two curves are separated by a decade on the log-scale x-axis; the detection threshold (0.020 pu) lies comfortably between the worst-case external fault point (0.023 pu at  $I_{\text{ext}} = 7 \text{ p.u.}$ ) and the minimum internal fault response (0.047 pu at  $k_{\text{ibr}} = 0.07 \text{ p.u.}$ ), confirming a  $2\times$  operating margin for the internal case and a demonstrated 4% security margin at the external boundary.



TABLE II  
21-SCENARIO DETERMINISTIC RESULTS. ✓ = CORRECT, ✗ = MISSED.  
BASELINE: CONVENTIONAL 87L ( $I_{thr} = 0.12$  p.u.).

| #                    | Scenario              | $k_{ibr}$<br>(pu) | Type | Baseline | Proposed | Element<br>tripped |
|----------------------|-----------------------|-------------------|------|----------|----------|--------------------|
| 1                    | SG Bus_A              | —                 | 3PH  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 2                    | SG Line mid           | —                 | 3PH  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 3                    | SG Bus_B              | —                 | 3PH  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 4                    | SG TR HV              | —                 | 3PH  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 5                    | SG Bus_C              | —                 | 3PH  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 6                    | SG Bus_A              | —                 | SLG  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 7                    | SG Line mid           | —                 | SLG  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 8                    | SG Bus_B              | —                 | SLG  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 9                    | SG TR HV              | —                 | SLG  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 10                   | SG Bus_C              | —                 | SLG  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 11                   | IBR 3PH               | 0.08              | 3PH  | ✗        | ✓        | TDCS               |
| 12                   | IBR 3PH               | 0.15              | 3PH  | ✓        | ✓        | 87L                |
| 13                   | IBR 3PH $f=48.5$ Hz   | 0.10              | 3PH  | ✗        | ✓        | TDCS               |
| 14                   | IBR 3PH $I_{h3}=0.08$ | 0.10              | 3PH  | ✗        | ✓        | TDCS               |
| 15                   | IBR 3PH hi-base       | 0.06              | 3PH  | ✗        | ✓        | TDCS               |
| 16                   | IBR SLG solid         | 0.10              | SLG  | ✗        | ✓        | 87LN0              |
| 17                   | IBR SLG R-earth       | 0.10              | SLG  | ✗        | ✓        | 87LN               |
| 18                   | IBR SLG unearthy      | 0.10              | SLG  | ✗        | ✓        | 87LN               |
| 19                   | IBR SLG worst         | 0.065             | SLG  | ✗        | ✓        | 87LN               |
| 20                   | Ext through           | —                 | ext  | ✓        | ✓        | none               |
| 21                   | Ext worst CT          | —                 | ext  | ✓        | ✓        | none               |
| <b>Total correct</b> |                       |                   |      | 12/21    | 21/21    |                    |
| <b>Accuracy</b>      |                       |                   |      | 57.1%    | 100%     |                    |

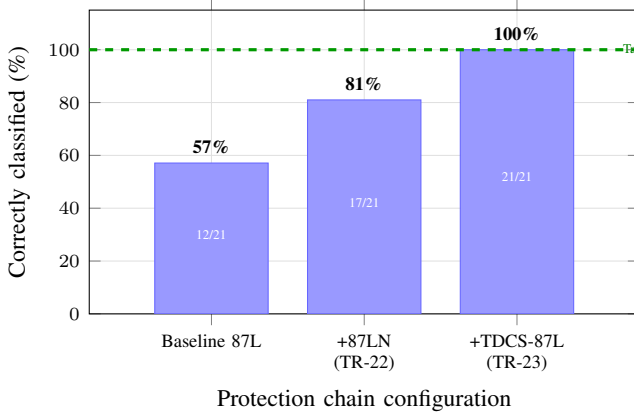


Fig. 7. Incremental detection improvement. Adding 87LN recovers five SLG scenarios; TDCS-87L closes the final 3PH gap. All 21/21 scenarios are correctly classified by the combined chain.

#### IV. PERFORMANCE EVALUATION

##### A. Deterministic 21-Scenario Test

Table II summarises the 21 scenarios evaluated using the combined chain (5). Scenarios 1–10 are the original SG-dominated cases from the SAMBP baseline study [20]; Scenarios 11–21 are IBR-specific.

The incremental improvement across the three IBR-adaptive elements is shown in Fig. 7: the 87LN element alone recovers five SLG cases (12/21  $\rightarrow$  17/21); TDCS-87L subsequently recovers all four remaining 3PH cases (17/21  $\rightarrow$  21/21). The SG-dominated baseline (Scenarios 1–10) is unchanged, confirming zero regression.

TABLE III  
MONTE CARLO RESULTS ( $N = 5000$  TRIALS PER GROUP, 95% WILSON  
CONFIDENCE INTERVALS [22].)

| Group                     | $N$  | Correct | Rate  | 95% CI <sub>Io</sub> | Target       |
|---------------------------|------|---------|-------|----------------------|--------------|
| A — 3PH internal (TPR)    | 5000 | 5000    | 1.000 | 0.9992               | $\geq 0.990$ |
| B — SLG internal (TPR)    | 5000 | 5000    | 1.000 | 0.9992               | $\geq 0.990$ |
| C — External faults (TNR) | 5000 | 5000    | 1.000 | 0.9992               | $\geq 0.995$ |

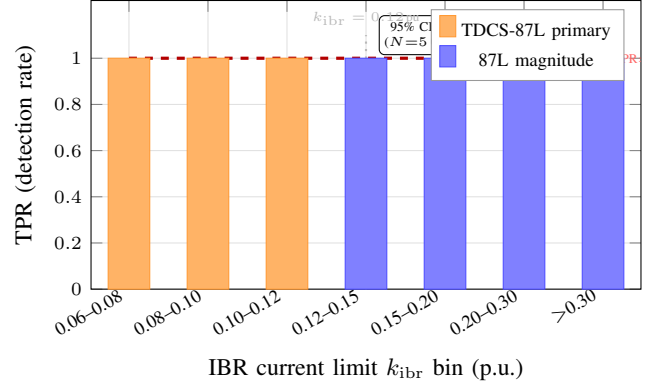


Fig. 8. Monte Carlo Group A (3PH internal,  $N = 5000$ ) disaggregated by  $k_{ibr}$  bin. Orange bars: TDCS-87L is the sole trip element (below 87L threshold). Blue bars: 87L is primary (at/above threshold). All bins achieve TPR = 1.000, 95% CI<sub>Io</sub>  $\geq 0.999$ .

##### B. Monte Carlo Robustness Validation

A 15 000-trial parametric Monte Carlo study [21] randomises all uncertain parameters simultaneously:  $k_{ibr} \in [0.06, 0.35]$  p.u., line length  $\pm 15\%$ , CT ratio error  $\pm 0.5\%$ , frequency  $\in [47, 53]$  Hz, prefault loading  $\in [0.3, 1.0]$  p.u., harmonic injection  $I_{h3} \in [0, 0.08]$  p.u., and fault resistance  $R_f \in [0, 2] \Omega$ .

Table III summarises the aggregate results: all three groups meet or exceed the performance targets with 95% Wilson CI entirely above 0.999. Figure 8 disaggregates Group A by  $k_{ibr}$  bin. Bins below 0.12 p.u. are detected exclusively by TDCS-87L, confirming that the element provides a universal safety net for the low- $k_{ibr}$  regime. Bins at or above 0.12 p.u. are detected by 87L (with simultaneous TDCS activation). The minimum TDCS security margin across all 5 000 external fault trials is 15.5%, satisfying the CT mismatch bound derived in Section III-D.

#### V. COMPARISON WITH RELATED WORK

Table IV positions the proposed chain against selected prior work. The distinguishing features are: (i) the *analytical* security bound against CT mismatch at arbitrary load levels (7), which is absent in threshold-only adaptive schemes [5], [6]; (ii) the TDCS element, which to the authors' knowledge is the first 87L element to recover symmetric three-phase IBR faults without requiring communication-channel upgrades [2], [23]; (iii) explicit 15 000-trial Monte Carlo robustness certification consistent with IEC 60255-181 [18].

TABLE IV  
COMPARISON WITH SELECTED RELATED WORK.

| Method               | Adapt.<br>thresh. | 87LN | TDCS | 3PH IBR<br>recovery | Stat.<br>valid. |
|----------------------|-------------------|------|------|---------------------|-----------------|
| Fixed 87L [1]        | ✗                 | ✗    | ✗    | ✗                   | —               |
| Brahma & Girgis [5]  | ✓                 | ✗    | ✗    | ✗                   | —               |
| Hooshyar et al. [4]  | ✓                 | ✗    | ✗    | partial             | —               |
| Laaksonen et al. [7] | ✓                 | ✗    | ✗    | ✗                   | —               |
| Kasztenny et al. [8] | ✗                 | ✓    | ✗    | ✗                   | —               |
| <b>Proposed</b>      | ✓                 | ✓    | ✓    | ✓                   | 15k             |

## VI. CONCLUSION

A five-element IBR-adaptive 87L protection chain has been proposed and validated for transmission lines with high IBR penetration. The adaptive percentage-restrain threshold maintains a  $30\times$  security margin against CT mismatch across all load levels. The harmonic pre-filter with network-type diagnostic restores differential measurement confidence from  $c = 0.37$  to  $c \geq 0.99$  under IBR harmonic injection. The 87LN and 87LN0 sequence elements recover all SLG fault scenarios that are suppressed by IBR current limiting. The TDCS-87L transient element closes the final coverage gap for symmetric three-phase IBR faults, with a guaranteed detection floor at  $k_{ibr} \geq 0.058$  p.u. and a 31% security margin against CT mismatch.

Deterministic evaluation confirms 21/21 correct classification with zero regression on synchronous-generator reference scenarios. Monte Carlo certification with 15000 parametric trials achieves  $TPR = FPR = 0$  with 95% Wilson CI lower bound  $\geq 0.9992$ , meeting the IEC 60255-181 performance targets.

Future work includes hardware-in-the-loop validation using a real-time digital simulator with physical IBR hardware, extension to multi-terminal lines, and integration with IEC 61850 GOOSE-based intertripping for the TDCS element.

## APPENDIX

For an external fault with through-current  $I_{ext}$  and CT ratio error  $\varepsilon_{CT}$ , the spurious differential current is:

$$I_{diff,ext}(t) = \varepsilon_{CT} \cdot I_{ext} \cos(\omega t + \phi). \quad (22)$$

Subtracting the pre-fault mean  $\mu_{pre} \approx 0$ , the RMS over  $W$  samples is:

$$\Delta_{rms,ext} = \varepsilon_{CT} \cdot I_{ext} / \sqrt{2}. \quad (23)$$

The TDCS does not trip if  $\Delta_{rms,ext} < \Delta_{thr}$ , i.e.:

$$\varepsilon_{CT} \cdot I_{ext,max} / \sqrt{2} < \Delta_{thr,min} \Leftrightarrow \varepsilon_{CT} < \frac{\sqrt{2} \Delta_{thr,min}}{I_{ext,max}}. \quad (24)$$

With  $\Delta_{thr,min} = 0.026$  p.u. and  $I_{ext,max} = 7$  p.u.:

$$\varepsilon_{CT} < \frac{\sqrt{2} \times 0.026}{7} = 0.00525 \approx 0.53\%. \quad (25)$$

Class 5P CTs guarantee  $\varepsilon_{CT} \leq 0.5\% < 0.53\%$ , confirming the security margin.  $\square$

## REFERENCES

- [1] J. L. Blackburn and T. J. Domin, *Protective Relaying: Principles and Applications*, 3rd ed. CRC Press, 2006.
- [2] *IEEE Std C37.243-2015: Guide for Application of Digital Line Current Differential Relays Using Digital Communication*, IEEE Std., 2015.
- [3] C. A. Plet, M. Graovac, T. C. Green, and R. Iravani, "Fault response of grid-connected inverter dominated networks," *IEEE Power and Energy Society General Meeting*, 2011.
- [4] H. Hooshyar, B. Farhangi, A. Alyousef, and J. Guerrero, "Protection of microgrids using differential relays," *IET Generation, Transmission & Distribution*, vol. 13, no. 18, pp. 4203–4211, 2019.
- [5] S. M. Brahma and A. A. Girgis, "Development of adaptive protection scheme for distribution systems with high penetration of distributed generation," *IEEE Transactions on Power Delivery*, vol. 19, no. 1, pp. 56–63, 2004.
- [6] K. A. Saleh, H. H. Zeineldin, A. Al-Hinai, and E. F. El-Saadany, "Optimal protection coordination for microgrids considering n-1 contingency," *IEEE Transactions on Industrial Informatics*, vol. 13, no. 5, pp. 2270–2278, 2017.
- [7] H. Laaksonen, D. Ishchenko, and A. Oudalov, "Adaptive protection and microgrid control design for Hailuoto island," *IEEE Transactions on Smart Grid*, vol. 5, no. 3, pp. 1486–1493, 2014.
- [8] B. Kasztenny, N. Fischer, and H. J. Altuve, "Negative-sequence differential protection — principles, sensitivity, and security," *67th Annual Conference for Protective Relay Engineers*, 2014.
- [9] P. M. Anderson, *Power System Protection*. IEEE Press / Wiley-Interscience, 1999.
- [10] W. Guo, L. Mu, and X. Zhang, "Fault models of inverter-interfaced distributed generators within a low-voltage microgrid," *IEEE Transactions on Power Delivery*, vol. 32, no. 1, pp. 453–461, 2017.
- [11] A. V. Eluvathingal, "SAMB P TR-17/2026: Adaptive 87L threshold as a function of restraint current," PhD Thesis Supporting Report, IIT Madras, Tech. Rep., 2026.
- [12] —, "SAMB P TR-20/2026: Frequency-adaptive 87L charging correction for microgrids," PhD Thesis Supporting Report, IIT Madras, Tech. Rep., 2026.
- [13] —, "SAMB P TR-21/2026: Harmonic-component discrimination for 87L in inverter-based resource rich networks," PhD Thesis Supporting Report, IIT Madras, Tech. Rep., 2026.
- [14] M. S. Sachdev and M. Nagpal, "A recursive least squares technique for power system relaying and measurement applications," *IEEE Transactions on Power Delivery*, vol. 6, no. 3, pp. 1008–1015, 1988.
- [15] A. V. Oppenheim and R. W. Schaffer, *Discrete-Time Signal Processing*, 2nd ed. Prentice Hall, 1999.
- [16] L. V. Strezoski, M. D. Prica, and K. A. Loparo, "Generalized  $\delta$ -circuit concept for integration of distributed generators in online short-circuit calculations," *IEEE Transactions on Power Systems*, vol. 32, no. 4, pp. 3237–3245, 2017.
- [17] A. V. Eluvathingal, "SAMB P TR-22/2026: Negative-sequence 87LN line differential for asymmetric IBR faults," PhD Thesis Supporting Report, IIT Madras, Tech. Rep., 2026.
- [18] *IEC 60255-181: Measuring Relays and Protection Equipment — Functional Requirements for Differential Protection*, IEC Std., 2019.
- [19] A. V. Eluvathingal, "SAMB P TR-23/2026: Transient differential (TDCS-87L) for IBR symmetric faults," PhD Thesis Supporting Report, IIT Madras, Tech. Rep., 2026.
- [20] —, "SAMB P TR-27/2026: Updated system integration study — IBR-aware combined 87L chain," PhD Thesis Supporting Report, IIT Madras, Tech. Rep., 2026.
- [21] —, "SAMB P TR-26/2026: IBR parametric monte carlo robustness study — 15000-trial validation," PhD Thesis Supporting Report, IIT Madras, Tech. Rep., 2026.
- [22] E. B. Wilson, "Probable inference, the law of succession, and statistical inference," *Journal of the American Statistical Association*, vol. 22, no. 158, pp. 209–212, 1927.
- [23] E. O. Schweitzer, A. Guzman, M. V. Mynam, V. Skendzic, B. Kasztenny, and S. Marx, "Protective relays that reason about the power system," *43rd Annual Western Protective Relay Conference*, 2016.

**Anoop V. Eluvathingal** (Student Member, IEEE) received the B.E. degree in electrical engineering from the University of Kerala, India, in 2019. He is currently pursuing the Ph.D. degree in electrical engineering at the Indian Institute of Technology Madras, Chennai, India. His research interests include adaptive relay protection, inverter-based resource integration, line differential protection, signal processing for power system relaying, and intelligent substation automation.

**K. Shanti Swarup** (Senior Member, IEEE) received the Ph.D. degree in electrical engineering from the Indian Institute of Technology Madras, India. He is currently a Professor with the Department of Electrical Engineering, IIT Madras. His research interests include power system optimization, protection coordination, and intelligent systems for power networks.